would be North Korea, Trump dramatically ratcheted up rhetoric against the rogue regime, warning that Pyongyang would face "fire and fury" if it threatened the United States or its allies with nuclear weapons. Trump increased military shows of force near the peninsula and sponsored a series of stronger UN sanctions to financially squeeze the Kim regime. This activity was capped by threats from the administration that it would preemptively strike North Korea, raining down "fire and fury" to degrade its nuclear and ballistic missile capability. Pyongyang's response through 2017 was to conduct another nuclear test and launch ballistic missiles on at least sixteen different occasions, including launching two over Hokkaido, Japan's main island, and theoretically achieving the capability of striking the US homeland.[37]

At the same time, Trump and his senior officials, including then secretary of defense James Mattis and then secretary of state Rex Tillerson, held open the possibility of another round of negotiations with Pyongyang. In a flurry of diplomatic activity in the spring of 2018, South Korean president Moon Jae-in announced that he would meet with Kim Jong-un, and Trump accepted an unprecedented offer for a summit with the North Korean dictator in Singapore in June 2018. Trump and his team credited their threatening rhetoric with bringing Kim to the negotiating table and quickly returned to the long-standing US goal of "complete, verifiable, and irreversible denuclearization" of the Korean Peninsula. Yet with little follow-through after that summit and a second one in Hanoi in February 2019, and amid reports that North Korea had restarted work on missile launching pads and nuclear facilities, it was clear that denuclearization of North Korea was as far away as it had been under prior administrations.

Of even greater significance, Trump adopted an approach toward China of alternating cooperative gestures with confrontational moves. The administration's first National Security Strategy, under the direction of then national security adviser H. R. McMaster and released in December 2017, laid to rest the idea that China would any longer be considered a unique partner of the United States, as pursued initially by the Obama administration. Rather, the document singled out